XUQIAN MA

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Health Economics

EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley — Berkeley, CA
PhD in Health Policy (Health Economics) — Expected May 2027
Dissertation: Essays on Preventive Health Behaviors

Cornell University — Ithaca, NY
MS in Economics (International and Development Economics) — May 2022

University of Minnesota Twin Cities — Minneapolis, MN
BS in Economics (Quantitative Economics and Econometrics) — May 2020

JOB MARKET PAPER

"What Do Measures of Decision-Making Ability Tell Us About Preventive Health Behavior? Evidence from Flu and COVID-19 Vaccination"

Vaccination is a choice under uncertainty that draws on two distinct abilities: forming beliefs about risks and acting consistently on one's own preferences. Using the Understanding America Study, I measure the first with cognitive tests of quantitative ability and the second with choice consistency in an incentivized revealed-preference experiment. For influenza (2014–2026), neither predicts vaccination on average, but receipt falls over time especially post COVID among the least consistent adults, most sharply among Republicans, and the consistency gap grows most among adults with fewer chronic conditions, groups likely to perceive less risk. For COVID-19 (2021), quantitative ability predicts who got vaccinated earlier. Higher-ability adults held more favorable beliefs about vaccine safety and effectiveness before most could get a dose, and these beliefs account for about 60 percent of the gap. After adjusting for baseline beliefs, lower-ability adults more often reported not knowing how to book or where to go. This points to prosocial and norm-based messages from messengers people trust for familiar vaccines, and to early, clear safety information and appointment guidance for new ones.

PUBLICATION

Ma, Xuqian, Michelle Layvant, Edward Miguel, Eric Ochieng, Ajay Pillarisetti, and Michael Walker. **"Impacts of contemporaneous air pollution exposure on cognitive performance in Kenya."** Journal of Health Economics (2026): 103166.

REVISE AND RESUBMIT

"Mitigating Cognitive Deficits from Prenatal Air Pollution: Experimental Evidence from a Nutrition Intervention". Xuqian Ma, Yuhang Pan, Lingling Hou, and Renfu Luo. *Revise and resubmit, Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists*

WORKING PAPER

"War, Memory, and Mind: The Long-Term Consequences of the Vietnam War". Xuqian Ma, William H. Dow and Yasuhiko Saito. *In preparation for submission*

PRESENTATIONS

American Society of Health Economists Annual Conference	2026
ESE–RGHI–GHE Workshop on Health Economics in LMICs	2026
Yale Workshop, "New Data, Methods, and Theory: Life-Course Cognitive Inequality"	2026
Population Association of America Annual Meeting	2025
Psychology and Economics of Poverty Convening	2024
Pacific Conference for Development Economics	2024
Asian Workshop on Econometrics and Health Economics	2023
Harvard Spatial Data Lab Webinar on Spatiotemporal Innovation	2023

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Health Economics — Fall 2026
MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; Brent Fulton

Economics of Population Health — Spring 2025, 2026
MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; William H. Dow

Cost-Effectiveness Analysis Spring 2025, 2026
MPH program, Berkeley Public Health; William H. Dow

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Center for Effective Global Action, UC Berkeley Berkeley, CA
Graduate Student Researcher; Principal Investigator: Edward Miguel May 2023–present
Kenya Life Panel Survey

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

Preparing Future Faculty UDL Working Group Grant	Summer 2025
Summer Research Fellowship	Summers 2023–2025
Best Poster Award, Population Association of America Annual Meeting	Spring 2025
Shortell/Schaeffer Fellowship	2024–2025
Berkeley Fellowship for Graduate Study	2022–2024
Berkeley Health Policy Department Conference Travel Grant	2023, 2025, 2026
Berkeley Graduate Division Conference Travel Grant	2023, 2026

METHODS AND SOFTWARE

Causal inference; machine learning; GIS and spatial analysis; R, Stata

REFERENCES

William H. Dow
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Edward Miguel
Professor, UC Berkeley Department of Economics
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Lingling Hou
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